As Lawrence was aware, there was no small irony in this. For months, the British had been describing Shuja as lazy and ineffectual, yet when the crisis broke it was Shuja alone who took immediate action to suppress the uprising in the city before it got out of hand. He had sent into action against the mob the loyal and long-standing Anglo-Indian commander of his personal guard, William Campbell, at the head of a thousand troops and two cannon, with Fatteh Jang adding his authority. Indeed, Shuja was the only person to make any effort to try to save Alexander Burnes, despite the fact that he had been the Shah's loudest critic for over a decade. As Lawrence waited with Shuja, reports began arriving of Fatteh Jang's successful progress into the city and his pacification of successive wards.

By mid-morning, however, events began to take a darker turn. First of all, Lieutenant Sturt arrived in the durbar 'sword in hand, bleeding profusely, and crying out that he was being murdered. He explained that just as he was dismounting from his horse at the gate, he had been stabbed three times in the face and throat by a man who rushed out of the crowd.' Reports then arrived that Campbell and Fatteh Jang's levies had been ambushed by insurgents in the narrow streets of the city, and had taken over a hundred casualties from marksmen hidden within the houses of the Shor Bazaar. They had lost their two cannon and were now pinned down a short distance from Burnes's house. Shuja became increasingly worried about his son and, despite Lawrence's pleas, 'influenced by paternal affection, after hesitating, eventually recalled his son and Prime Minister. The latter, a bold, honest, uncompromising man eventually came in panting from the fray, and greatly excited, said in an angry tone to the King, "By recalling us just at the moment of victory, your troops will be defeated, and evil will fall upon us all."'[6]

After a sleep of only three hours, Mohan Lal was woken just before dawn by a maidservant who told him in alarm about the massing crowd outside Burnes's gate, a few houses away at the end of the bazaar: 'Agha,' she said. 'You are asleep and the city is upset.'

Mohan Lal came out into his garden, and saw the people moving their goods to a secure place away from the neighbourhood.